2 The Hasdeo Arand Forest

Spanning over 1650 square kilometres in Chhattisgarh, Hasdeo Arand is known as the “lungs of central India”, a biodiversity hotspot, elephant corridor, and home to indigenous Adivasi communities whose culture and survival rely on the forest. Under Indian law, village councils (Gram Sabhas) have the constitutional right to decide what happens to their ancestral land.

Beneath this ancient canopy, however, lie billions of tons of coal. Over the past decade, state agencies and corporate developers have systematically cleared vast tracts of the forest, designating them as open-cast coal blocks.

Official reports describe this extraction as essential national development and responsible stewardship. In response, local communities argue that clearances bypass their consent and destroy their watershed. The following exhibits document this unfolding clash: official environmental clearances and corporate brochures on one side, and village resolutions, forest blockades, and community defense on the other.

SAME ACT, TWO NAMES

coal blocks · “development” · “stewardship” · clearance

vs

ancestral forest · consent refused · our watershed